—Dinpanah. Built just south of Feroze Shah Kotla, along the river Yamuna, it included a citadel that we now know as Purana Qila (or Old Fort). As we have already discussed, it was said to be the site of ancient Indraprastha. There is nothing to suggest that this historical association had anything to do with the choice of location. In addition to the citadel, there was a fortified city. Unfortunately, very little has survived of the city of Dinpanah except one of its impressive gates—the Lal Darwaza (or Red Gate). One can see this imposing structure across the road from Purana Qila and Delhi Zoo.

Humayun did not complete either Dinpanah or Purana Qila. He was chased out by a group of Afghan rebels led by Sher Shah Suri and escaped with his family to Persia. It was Sher Shah who completed Purana Qila. He was also a remarkable administrator who carried out many key reforms during his short reign. He re-organized tax collection, minted the first silver Rupiya (precursor to the modern Rupee), and revived the ancient city of Pataliputra (Patna). He also rebuilt the ancient Uttara Path highway from Punjab to Bengal. Known as ‘Sadak-e-Azam’ (or Great Road), it would be a major artery of the Mughal period; the British would know it as the Grand Trunk Road and it is now part of the Golden Quadrilateral highway network.

If Sher Shah Suri had lived longer, it is possible that we would not remember Mughal rule as anything more than one more Central Asian raid. However, he died in a gun powder-related accident after just five years on the throne and Humayun was able to come back and re-occupy Delhi. Humayun too did not enjoy the Purana Qila for long, dying in a curious incident. He had gone to watch the rise of Venus from the roof of his library. One his way down the steep stairs, he tripped on his robe and died from the fall. Humayun’s library building survives in Purana Qila. The stairway, however, is not open to the public and visitors trying to re-enact Humayun’s last moments will be disappointed.

A thirteen-year-old Akbar now became the new ruler. He is usually called the third Mughal Emperor but, in reality, it was he who created the foundations of a stable empire. He not only continued Sher Shah’s reforms